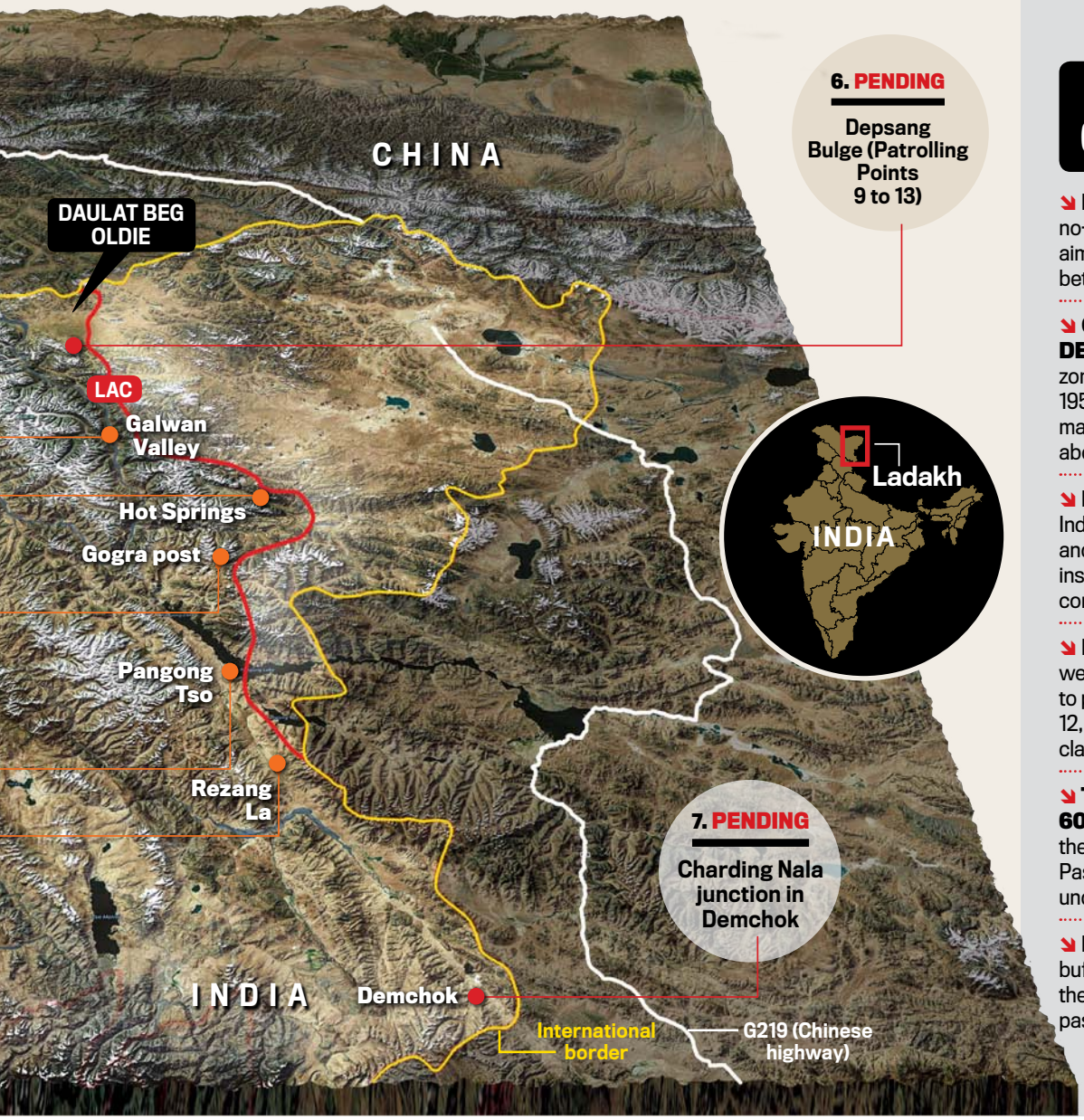



## AREAS OF CONTENTION

- **BUFFER ZONES** or no-patrolling areas are aimed at reducing clashes between troops
- **CHINA HAS BEEN DEMANDING** buffer zones ever since the 1950s. But the 1962 war made India apprehensive about its intentions
- **PLA HAS BLOCKED** Indian soldiers in Depsang and intruded around 18 km inside what India considers its own territory
- **INDIAN TROOPS** were prevented from going to patrolling points 10, 11, 12, 12A and 13 after the clashes in April-May 2020
- **THERE ARE OVER 60** patrolling points from the west of the Karakoram Pass to Chumar on the undemarcated border
- **LOCALS CLAIM** buffer zones compromise their access to traditional pasture land

*Graphic by* NILANJAN DAS AND TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

pressure across the borders and stretching India," says Lt Gen. Sharma. A senior army officer says full de-escalation does not seem to be possible in the near future because the PLA has built permanent camps for its formations, created infrastructure and effected demographic change through the construction of border villages, which are being populated by migrants from Xinjiang. "Changing the status of these demilitarised areas is not going to be easy, and they will be part of the LAC for some time," he says.

Besides the military, the locals too are concerned. Konchok Stanzin, who represents Chushul in the Ladakh Hill Development Council, laments that the creation of the latest buffer zone has effectively blocked local citizens' access to PP16. He fears that this could in turn threaten local communities' rights to their traditional grazing land in the Kugrang Valley, turning it into another patch of disputed territory. Stanzin says disengagement affects around 150 nomad families in the Chushul region, with a majority of pasture land being converted into no-patrol zones. "After each disengagement, a buffer zone was created in Indian territory. We are relenting to Chinese demands by giving them free access to our territory. Grazing grounds, which are already scarce in Ladakh, have been given away," Konchok says, adding that the policy is contrary to the government's desire to settle villagers in border areas to counter Chinese designs at the LAC. He also alleges that an overly defensive Indian army restricts the use of pasture land for nomads, while the Chinese do the opposite—use their villagers to transgress into Indian territory. "Nomads on the Indian side can be the eyes and ears of the army, they should not be restricted," Konchok adds.

Ultimately, the buffer zones on the LAC are meant to be a step towards resolving the long-pending border dispute between India and China. They must not be allowed to be instruments for an expansionist PLA to grab more territory. ■